Social Audit

Accompanying the RTI is the practice of social audits (given legal sanction in the MGNREGA) that empowers citizens to, quite literally, turn in to auditors to scrutinise government records, and through public hearings directly demand accountability for government actions. Implemented with varying degrees of enthusiasm by the state, social audits represent an important platform for making the idea of citizen's empowerment and direct demand for government accountability a tangible reality.



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Self Help Groups

Walk into the remotest of village in India, and chances are you will meet women, young and old, who are members of a local Self Help Group (SHG)—informal associations that enable access to low-cost credit. A revolution of sorts in women's financial inclusion was unleashed in the 1970s when a pioneering non-profit mobilised women's trade unions to set up the SEWA bank. Soon, the SHG movement was embraced by governments across India and the globe, and is today a critical tool not just for enabling women's access to finance but also social networks and capacity for collective action.

Accredited Social Health Activists

In a country where government struggles to fill vacancies in clinics and doctors rarely show up to work (absenteeism rates are as high as 40 per cent), it is the army of ASHAs who deliver health services–and hope–to much of India. Since 2005, India has recruited and trained nearly one million ASHAs, who live and work in the local community as part of one of the largest community health worker programmes in the world. Through the pandemic, it was the ASHAs who crossed mountains and rivers, braving the fear of disease, to deliver healthcare and vaccinate much of India.

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